

Chapter 151_1 - Demonic Aura

Though this night had bright moon and few stars, it was not peaceful. The immortal sects stayed awake waiting, while the people of the mortal realm slept soundly in their dreams, unaware that danger was approaching.

The first to receive news was Tianxuan Sword Sect. Tang Wenshu was standing atop the tower observing the heavens when the compass in his hand suddenly trembled and hummed, then the black iron shattered completely. In his shock, Tang Wenshu saw points of light flying from the distance.

Looking carefully, it was the sweating Elder Songxiang, with Zhou Yantan following behind him. The two landed breathlessly, Elder Songxiang too anxious and nearly falling to his knees.

Tang Wenshu quickly steadied him, asking in surprise: "What has happened to cause such panic?"

"This is terrible, Sect Leader! The Central Plains has had an earthquake!" Elder Songxiang shook his beard, crying out in anguish.

"The Central Plains have always been stable—how could there be an earthquake?" Tang Wenshu was greatly alarmed. Recalling the shattered compass in his hand, he immediately felt palpitations. "How many casualties?"

"With Qi Kingdom¹ as the center, there have been great tremors everywhere, including nearby Fragrant Mountain. Qi Kingdom is now in complete ruins, with countless civilian deaths and injuries, crying to heaven like hell itself! Many demons and evil spirits are taking advantage of the chaos, making the mortal world a mess of smoke and miasma!" Elder Songxiang spoke rapidly, then drew a semicircle before him.

The circle revealed scenes from the mortal world—collapsed bridges, diverted waterways, houses reduced to rubble, streets filled with fleeing disaster victims, severed limbs and hands everywhere.

As the semicircle slowly turned, Tang Wenshu watched helplessly as a woman holding an infant was buried under a collapsed beam. Amid the piercing screams, he broke out in cold sweat and quickly waved away the semicircle, unable to bear watching anymore.

"Quickly, deploy sect disciples to provide aid!" Tang Wenshu's burns that had not yet healed began to ache again. "Also, rapidly inform other sects so they can prepare."

"Yes." Zhou Yantan quickly took the order and left, his figure descending from the high tower.

"We're to go to Penglai tomorrow, and today such a great disaster occurs—this is too much of a coincidence!" Tang Wenshu paced with his hands behind his back, his footsteps thudding loudly. "But if it's not a coincidence, Penglai's heart is truly detestable, bringing disaster upon innocent mortals. Their hearts deserve death!"

"Who says otherwise?" Elder Songxiang anxiously pulled out a handful of beard. "If that Emperor Tianrui can truly control mountains and rivers, we're in great danger!"

"I hope," Tang Wenshu frowned as he gazed toward the distant dark heaven and earth, murmuring, "I hope it's just a coincidence."

Meanwhile, in the distant Penglai Realm.

The Penglai great hall was peaceful, even more peaceful than usual, because Emperor Tianrui's eyes were full of delight as he sat behind heavy curtains, sipping spring tea mouthful by mouthful, filling the entire hall with tea fragrance.

Outside the curtains, several people stood with bowed bodies.

"Emperor, the immortal sects have been restless these past few days, recalling disciples from everywhere. It seems they already have plans to surround and attack Penglai," Wen Yao Jun said with lowered head.

"Mere immortal sects, overestimating themselves." Emperor Tianrui seemed unmoved, instead rounding his mouth to blow away the foam on his tea. "This lord has long seen through their ambitions—attempting to destroy Penglai so the immortal realm would have no leader, with only the immortal sects as supreme afterward."

"Then Emperor, shall we let them act as they will?" Wen Yao Jun asked.

"Jumping clowns—let them be." Emperor Tianrui smiled as he set down his teacup. "If they dare come, this lord will show them who truly rules heaven and earth."

"The Emperor is a descendant of the god race. Searching all six realms, there's probably no one who can match you. If the immortal sects dare invade, we will defend Penglai with our lives and never let those rebels succeed," Wen Yao Jun said with burning eyes.

"I hope so. You may go." Emperor Tianrui looked down at his tea, his voice smooth.

Watching everyone disperse, the man sighed softly, set down his teacup, and picked up needle and thread, stroking with fascination the embroidery of the six realms' mountains and rivers beside him that lacked only a few final stitches to complete.

At this moment, footsteps sounded again outside the door. A pretty figure in pink robes and green skirt ran lightly into the hall, holding a purple stone cup in her hands, sweetly calling "Father Emperor."

The man then stopped his actions, hiding the needle and thread behind him with his other hand, and walked out from behind the curtains with a smile.

"Why does Shiqi always come here these days?" the man asked.

"Father Emperor won't let Shiqi leave Penglai anymore. Shiqi is bored with nothing to do, and those immortal attendants are no fun either. Besides Father Emperor's place, where else can I go?" Baili Shiqi bit her lip and walked to the table, placing the stone cup on it.

"This is tea I made with morning dew. Father Emperor, please try it."

When the man looked at Baili Shiqi, his eyes strangely shifted for a moment, then he walked down the steps and sat at the table, lowering his head to pick up the stone cup.

"Clear color, pleasant fragrance—truly good tea."

The man set down the stone cup: "Father Emperor forbids you from leaving Penglai again. Do you have complaints?"

Baili Shiqi sat in the chair and tugged at her skirt, lowering her head: "I do have complaints."

The man smiled, raised his hand to drink the tea, then consoled: "Father Emperor knows you like reading those mortal realm story books, dreaming of wandering the martial world. Father Emperor has never stopped this, but now the immortal sects and Penglai have deep conflicts. For the immortal sects, Penglai is no longer friend but enemy. If I let you go out again, I fear you might meet with misfortune."

"Shiqi understands," Baili Shiqi replied obediently.

"Shiqi is most well-behaved. What you usually do, Father Emperor is not unaware of. It's only because you are my only daughter that I pretend not to hear. Father Emperor doesn't know what rumors you've heard outside, but you must always remember—you are a Penglai person, and what flows in your bones is our Penglai blood."

Baili Shiqi gripped her dress tighter and said nothing more.

Fortunately, Emperor Tianrui didn't seem to dwell on this matter. Instead, he placed a point of light on the table and said kindly: "In a few days the world may have great chaos. Father Emperor fears you cannot protect yourself."

"This is a pill to increase cultivation. Eat it, and Father Emperor can feel more at ease."

Baili Shiqi looked at the pill glowing on its surface. Her fan-like eyelashes covered the thoughts in her eyes, but her hands didn't hesitate. She directly picked up the pill and put it in her mouth.

The man stared intently as Baili Shiqi swallowed the pill. His smile deepened, creases forming two furrows beside his mouth, then he slowly stood up.

"Father Emperor still has business. Go back to your room and rest."

Baili Shiqi lowered her head and left. She walked through the quiet flower garden, slipped into the artificial mountain amid the insect chirping, leaned against the rocks and dry-heaved for a moment, then spat out the pill that hadn't yet dissolved.

The glowing sphere fell to the ground with a plop. Baili Shiqi raised her hand to turn it to ash, wiped away the moisture at the corners of her eyes, then walked out as normal, slowly returning to her room.

On the other side, the man watched the woman's smoke-green dress disappear into the distance before returning behind the curtains, picking up needle and thread again to embroider the final mountain range.

After finishing the embroidery, joy flowed in his eyes. Then he raised the needle and made a cut on his wrist, so drops of thick black blood flew up like strung pearls, seeping into the needle and thread.

The bloodstains disappeared without a trace. The originally unremarkable silk thread flashed with light, finally spreading to the entire embroidered piece in the hall. Those threads embroidering the six realms' mountains and rivers glowed strand by strand, vivid and lifelike.

"The Mountain and River Map is finally complete," the man murmured, his large hand greedily stroking the curtain beside him. "Chu Qingqiu, you think that by destroying the Wuji ghost fire, I have no more strategies?"

"Your death—and all of yours—is not far off!" He grinned widely, then suddenly inserted two fingers into the glowing Mountain and River Map.

Though his fingers penetrated the curtain, the embroidered piece wasn't damaged, only scorched black in one spot.

Under the scorched area, two blurred characters were embroidered: Qi Kingdom.

Footnotes:

1. **Qi Kingdom (岐国)** - A kingdom in the Central Plains region of the mortal realm